firing mortars at them since 8.30 in the morning, did not pursue the battalion at that stage. As the battalion began to pull out, the intensity of mortar fire also increased and the Chinese began to hit at the troops as they tried to make their way up. At this the battalion lost all cohesion in its dash to get to the upper reaches.

Breaking contact and withdrawing a large body of men, especially in the mountains, is an intricate, high-risk manoeuvre that requires pre-selection, preparation and occupation of fallback positions. The synchronized leapfrogging backwards from Bridge 2 towards Hathung-la and Lumpu, in broad daylight, would have required a lot of skill and coordination. Obviously, the CO of 9 Punjab decided that his best bet to avoid being further shelled by the Chinese was to get away from the river as fast as he could. He seems to have decided that it was a lost cause and had no intention of fighting it out at Hathung-la or anywhere else. Of all the battalions in the Nam Ka Chu Valley, 9 Punjab was the most battle-hardened. They had been there right from the very beginning and were fully acclimatized; Mishra had taken over the battalion just days before it was moved to Nam Ka Chu and if he as their CO had given them a chance, 9 Punjab would have certainly performed most creditably.

No sooner had the withdrawal started than chaos struck as small parties tried to make their way up cross-country through an area that had no tracks. Devoid of any protection overhead or on the ground, the unit suffered terrible losses. Over the next few hours, quite a few men were killed as they lost their footing and plunged over cliffs. Among them was Major Mahander Singh Chaudhary, under whose command the engagement with the Chinese had taken place on 10 October. The officer slipped and fell near the top of the 18,000-foot Dhola summit, landing on a ledge below a sheer cliff. Both his legs appeared to be broken. Some men tried to tie their turbans together in a bid to extricate him. A soldier tried to lower himself, but the turbans broke and the man plunged to his death. The rest of the men then abandoned the officer.

Seeing no sign of 9 Punjab, 4 Grenadiers decided to pull out at 3.30 p.m. Once again, just as the battalion began to withdraw, Oscar Thomas ascertained from his men at Hathung-la and Serkhim that there were still no Chinese troops in their vicinity.

Bravo Company under the command of Major Balbir Singh was the only company to have deployed a platoon across the Nam Ka Chu between